that the CM, who had had a long day, would not meet them. But they probably didn't know of Vishnu Deo's mild-mannered, affable style of functioning. Others vouch for his inherently inclusive nature. "Even if it takes another two hours, Vishnu Deoji will meet everyone. That's how he has been ever since his MLA days. He understands the importance of a personal connect," says a businessman from Korba who has known him for many years. Just then, the CM appeared in the waiting hall and greeted everyone, many of them by their first name—a clear sign of a man who has risen through the ranks. When he finally had time to speak with INDIA TODAY, it was well past midnight.

Having been entrusted by the BJP high command to lead the government only a few months before the country votes in the Lok Sabha election, Vishnu Deo is aware of the tough task before him but is confident of fulfilling it. "PM Modi has called on us to ensure qualitative improvement in the lives of the poor, the farmers and tribals. My government will be guided by these principles," he tells INDIA TODAY.

Each of Vishnu Deo's predecessors was identified with a distinct policy push. The Ajit Jogi years (2000-2003) were about building infrastructure in a new state; Raman Singh (2003-2018) continued that project and added emphasis on welfare, especially in the public distribution system and healthcare. Bhupesh Baghel's government (2018-2023) had a pro-rural push—putting money in the hands of farmers via bonuses. Three months into office, Vishnu Deo will have to spell out his vision for Chhattisgarh.

One of them is development of tribal areas. "The BJP has always been more committed to the development of tribals. Our objective is to fulfil the basic needs of tribals—housing, education, electricity and toilets," says Vishnu Deo.

"The government has identified



A CM KEEPS HIS PLEDGE

- **Post the formation of Chhattisgarh, its first undisputed tribal CM, Vishnu Deo Sai, is focusing on fulfilling key points in the BJP manifesto—'Modi ki Guarantee'**
- **Rs 3,716 crore has been paid to 1.3 million farmers as part of a backlog payment for two years for paddy procurement. Current procurement from 2.4 million farmers at Rs 3,100 a quintal, much above MSP of Rs 2,183**
- **Under the Mahtari Vandan Scheme launched on March 10, Rs 1,000 is being paid every month to 7 million women**
- **1.8 million beneficiaries identified for PM Awas Yojana**
- **CBI probe announced in the state public service commission recruitment scandal during the previous Congress regime**
- **Online transport permit system for coal transportation brought in to curb alleged corruption under Congress regime**
- **One-time relaxation of five years in upper age limit for state residents applying for government jobs**